While India had no interest in SEATO, its neighbor Pakistan did. News of Pakistani negotiations with the US for military aid, which began in spring 1953, had become public in November 1953. Subsequently, in February 1954, the US had confirmed it would provide military aid. A few months later, Pakistan offered to join SEATO, and US policymakers reluctantly accepted.[80]

There was an outcry in India against the inclusion of Pakistan in the US strategic script.[81] Nehru called it an "intrusion of a new and dangerous element in the politics of Asia," one that required an Indian policy rethink.[82] Nehru told the home minister that the US would likely play a restraining role on Pakistan vis-à-vis India because "such a conflict would upset their larger plans in Asia." But he was extremely anxious about Pakistan's increased access to military equipment and the implications for Indian defense expenditures.[83]

Had India's China policy affected the US decision to ally with Pakistan? Robert J. McMahon has argued that "American disillusionment with and devaluation of India" was definitely "a necessary precondition" for it.[84] That devaluation had partly stemmed from India's lack of willingness to play the role vis-à-vis China that Washington had hoped it would. The role it *had* played had not been helpful. The disillusionment, too, partly flowed from what US policymakers saw as India's lack of understanding of the China threat and the American approach toward China. Beyond Delhi's willingness, questions about India's ability to stand up to China also contributed to the decision to go the collective security route. The idea of alliances and partnerships in the region itself partly stemmed from the belief that while India and Japan were potentially considerably strong, at that point, as the NSC statement of policy on China noted, they lacked the ability to resist the communists effectively. Thus noncommunist Asia needed "protection against Communist attack."[85]

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Most Indian policymakers disagreed that India needed such protection and objected even more vociferously to the way the Eisenhower administration envisioned protecting Asia. Indeed, in mid-1953, US intelligence analysts